

N and M

Witsuwit'en has two *nasal* consonants, **m** and **n**. They are called nasals because the sound comes out the nose. **N** is more common than **m** in Witsuwit'en.

Nasal + C clusters

In Witsuwit'en, words can begin with one of these nasal sounds (**n** or **m**) directly followed by a consonant, forming a consonant cluster. This is the third type of word-initial consonant cluster found in Witsuwit'en. All of the “wh- question” words in Witsuwit'en begin with one of these nasal consonant clusters. Here are some of them:

ndu	‘what’
mbi	‘who’
nts'ë	‘where’
nts'ëts	‘from where’
nts'ëwh	‘when (in the present or future)’
nkëde'	‘when (in the past)’
nditni	‘which’

There are also some words that can begin with a nasal consonant cluster, or else the **n** can be dropped with no change in meaning:

nyin ~ yin	‘you’
nggi ~ ggi	‘that’
ndi ~ di	‘this’
ndik ~ dik	‘(straight) up’
nyik ~ yik	‘(straight) down’

Some forms of another class of words (stative verbs) often begin with **n** directly followed by a consonant but sometimes a longer form **hin** is used at the beginning of such words:

ndet ~ hindet	‘it’s narrow’
ndez ~ hindez	‘he/she/it is heavy’
nli ~ hinli	‘he/she/it is’

N vs. NI

Words can also begin with **niC**; that is, **ni** followed by a consonant. Since **i** is a short vowel, often unstressed, these may sound like nasal consonant clusters, but be aware that the two sequences are different. Compare:

ndide ‘he/she is sick’	nidide ‘he/she is out picking berries (walking)’
nde ‘your mouth (outside)’	nideyh ‘he/she is dancing’
ntsiy ‘it’s bad’	nitsiy ‘crest’
ngis ‘your hook’	nigit ‘fear’
nt'ayik ‘your chest’	nit'ay ‘berry’
nye ‘your lice’	niye ‘he/she is walking around’
nzul ‘your throat, collar’	nizut ‘he/she is skating around’

As just seen, many words with **n** or **m** directly followed by a consonant include ‘your’ in their meaning. Such words contain the short form of the possessive prefix ‘your’. There is also a long form of the prefix ‘your’, **ny-**, which must be used before a vowel:

nyuzi’ ‘your name’	uzi’ ‘name’
nyilhtsen ‘your brother’	cf. bilhtsen ‘his brother’

The long form must also be used before a nasal **n** or **m**, and usually also before **’** and **h**.

nyinñ ‘your face’	binñ ‘his/her face’
nyimñ ‘your cheek’	bimñ ‘his/her cheek’
nyi’at ‘your wife’	bi’at ‘his wife’
nyihalho’ ‘your cloth’	bihalho’ ‘his/her cloth’

The long form **nyi-** is also usually used before **s** or **z**:

nyisunye’ ~ nsunye’ ‘your money’	sunye’ ‘money’
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Otherwise, the long or the short form of ‘your’ can be used before other consonants. (The short forms seem to be more common.)

mbet ~ nyibet	‘your mittens’
ndzut ~ nyidzut	‘your coat’
nle ~ nyile	‘your hand’

The object of postposition prefix ‘you’ has similarly distributed long and short forms:

nlegh ’est’ën’ ~ nyilegh ’est’ën’	‘I helped you’
mbe c’izu’ ~ nyibe c’izu’	‘it’s good for you, it’s okay with you’

N’ and M’

N or **m** can form another type of consonant cluster with **’**: **n’** or **m’**. These clusters only occur at the end of a word or before a suffix, never at the beginning of a word. Here are some examples of **n’** and **m’** at the end of a word:

halht’im’	‘it’s small’
ntsin’	‘downhill’
ts’it’an’	‘it (object) is thin’
dzuzt’an’	‘shirt’
lhghen’ ~ hilhghen’	‘evening’
k’ilen’ ~ k’ilen	‘rear wall of feast hall’

before the pl. suffix –ñi

halht’im’ñi	‘small ones’
ntsin’ñi	‘downhill ones’

M vs. M'

dicin dilht'im 'it's gnawing, pecking wood' halht'im 'it's little'

N vs. N'

bin 'lake'	bin' 'morning'
yin 'land'	yin' 'floor'
nyen 'across'	yen' 'bridge'
	nyen' 'your bridge'
ditsin 'it's dirty'	c'itsin' 'fly, housefly'
yĭn 'moss'	diyĭn' 'wild potato'
dicin 'wood, wooden'	dzilh cin' 'at the foot of the mountain'
tsan 'excrement'	c'ikak tsan' 'apron'
dĭzk'in 'it's burning'	dilk'in' 'it's red'
'it'ĕn 'work'	nĭ'it'ĕn' 'he/she is working (around the house)'

There are two suffixes of the shape –' which can be added to words that end in **n** or **m**, creating more examples of the clusters **n'** or **m'**:

possessive suffix	
kwin 'fire'	skwin' 'my fire'
k'on 'fish eggs'	bik'on' 'its (fish's) eggs'
ts'ilim 'packed lunch'	bits'ilim' 'his/her packed lunch'
one of the past tense suffixes	
is'ĕn 'I see it'	is'ĕn' 'I saw it'
ustan 'I'm holding it'	ustan' 'I held it'
'et stan 'it (rigid object) is there'	'et ĭtan' 'it (rigid object) was there'
'et siyĭn 'he/she is standing there'	'et ĭnyĭn' 'he/she stood there'
so'indzin 'he/she is fine'	so'ĕndzin' 'he/she was fine'
c'oniyĭn 'he/she is picking berries (in one spot)'	c'onĭnyĭn' 'he/she picked berries'

n' vs. 'n

Be aware that **n'** is also different from **'n**. The latter sequence can arise when a word that ends in ' is suffixed with **–nĭ**.

c'ide' 'anciently'	c'ide'nĭ 'ancestors'
c'izu' 'good'	c'izu'nĭ 'good ones'

The sequence **'n** can be found in the middle of a word too:

bika'niszin	'I want it'
bika'nĭszĭn'	'I wanted it'

Furthermore, notice that **'n** is not the same as **'in**, which also occurs in the middle of a word:

so'indzin	'he/she is okay'
ne'indinil'ĕn	'he/she is looking at him/herself'

ho'ints'iy ~ ho'ints'idit

'however, even so'

Compare:

dic'a'nist'ën' 'I did wrong'
yika'nīnzīn 'he/she wants it'

dic'a'int'ën' 'he/she did wrong, died'
yika'intazīlh 'he/she will want it'

Stress in trisyllabic and longer words

Review: if a word contains two syllables, and the vowel of the first syllable contains **i**, the main stress falls on the second syllable:

nideyh
nisdeyh

'he/she is dancing'
'I'm dancing'

If the first vowel of a two-syllable word is other than **i**, then stress falls on the first syllable of the word:

nudeyh
nīnudeyh

'let him/her dance'
'(you) dance'

If a word contains three syllables, the first two vowels are **i**, and there are no syllable-final consonants in the first two syllables, stress falls on either the first or last syllable:

nīdideyh ~ nidideyh
hīnideyh ~ hinideyh
ts'inideyh ~ ts'inideyh
nīsikwiz ~ nisikwiz

'we 2 are dancing'
'they're dancing'
'we're dancing'
'he/she drove around'

If either of the first two syllables contain a syllable-final consonant (all vowels in the first two syllables being **i**), stress falls on the syllable which ends in a consonant:

nīsizut
nīsdidzut

'I skated around'
'we 2 skated around'

If both of the first two syllables contain a syllable-final consonant, the stress falls on the leftmost:

nīsditkwiz

'we 2 drove around'

If the either of the first two syllables contains a vowel other than **i**, then stress falls on that syllable, regardless of whether the other syllable (in the first two syllables) contains a syllable-final consonant:

wintadeyh
nūditkwiz

'there will be a dance'
'let's (du.) drive around'

If both vowels of the first two syllables contain a vowel other than **i**, then stress falls on the leftmost:

nuzinge ~ nuzintge

‘you were hunting, stalking’

What about stress in longer words? The same rules basically apply...

Long vowels

(Review) the vowels of the Witsuwit'en writing system are:

a e ë i i o u

Six of these, all but **i**, have a corresponding long vowel:

aa ee ëë i i oo uu

The long vowels are pronounced according just like the short vowels (their sound is affected by the neighbouring consonants) but they take more time to say. Some people describe them as “dragged” vowels. Compare:

so’ ‘good, well’

halht’um’ yez ‘it’s really small’

soo’~hoo’ ‘no’

halht’uum’ yez ‘it’s really small’

Long vowels are most common in verbs that have ‘they’ or ‘them’ in the translation:

silh yelhdic ‘he’s talking to me’

yikh hot’iy’ ‘he had a house’

nīnīnye ‘he went and stayed’

kēdīzilh ‘she’s travelling’

netl’adīde ‘she sat down’

ts’ēneniclhhdzit ‘I woke him/her up’

nibī udil’ēkh ‘she’s learning how to swim’

silh yeelhdic ‘they’re talking to me’

yikh hoot’iy’ ‘they had a house’

nīnīnīndīl ‘they went and stayed’

kēēdīdikh ‘they’re travelling’

netl’aadīlts’iy ‘they sat down’

ts’ēneebiniclhhdzit ‘I woke them up’

naabī uudil’ēkh ‘they’re learning how to swim’

Another aspect of the pronunciation of the long vowels is that if a word contains a syllable with a long vowel, that syllable is stressed.¹³ So:

netl’aadīlts’iy

silh yeelhdic

ts’ēneebiniclhhdzit

nīnīnīndīl

kēēdīdikh

yikh hoot’iy’

naabī uudil’ēkh

‘they sat down’

‘they’re talking to me’

‘I woke them up’

‘they went and stayed’

‘they’re travelling’

‘they had a house’

‘they’re learning how to swim’

¹³In the rare case that there are two syllables with long vowels in the word, they are both more or less equally stressed: ts’ēneebaalhdzit ‘they are waking them up’.

How do these long vowels in ‘they’-subject or ‘them’-object verbs arise? The basic form of the verb prefix meaning ‘they (humans, higher animals)’ is **hi-** and the basic form of the verb prefix meaning ‘them (humans, higher animals)’ is **hibi-**. The long vowels arise because of a pronunciation rule that **h** must be deleted between two vowels in Witsuwit’en:

silh yeelhdi (< *silh yeilhdic* < *silh yehilhdic*)

A further source of **aa** in Witsuwit’en is that when **i** is in a context where one of these long vowel forms is expected to occur, **i** lengthens to **aa**.

<i>nibī</i> ‘he/she is swimming around’	<i>naabī</i> ‘they’re swimming around’
<i>’it’ah</i> ‘he/she is working (for a wage)’	<i>’aat’ah</i> ‘they’re working.’
<i>hine</i> ‘he/she is alive’	<i>haane</i> ‘they’re alive’
<i>nī’it’ën</i> ‘he/she is working (around the house)’	<i>nī’aat’ën</i> ‘they’re working...’

A further source of **īī** in Witsuwit’en occurs in verbs where **ī** might be expected to be followed by **y**- third person singular object. First study these examples. The first example contains **c’(i)**- ‘something’. In the second example, **y**- ‘him/her/it’ occurs in place of **c’**-

<i>nec’itat’ëlh</i>	‘he/she is going to see something/someone again’
<i>neytat’ëlh</i>	‘he/she is going to see him/her again’

In the next pair of examples, the first one contains **c’(i)**- ‘something’ again. In the second example, you would expect **y**- ‘it’ to occur where the **c’(i)**- is, but instead **ī+y** → **īī**.

<i>’et nīc’inīn’ay</i>	‘he/she contributed something’ (lit. ‘he/she put
something down there’)	
<i>winīze ’et nīīnīn’ay</i>	‘he contributed ten (dollars)’

Writing practice 7

_____	‘a nest (of something)’
_____	‘whip’
_____	‘by the fire’
_____	‘half, in the middle’
_____	‘pine tree’
_____	‘maybe’
_____	‘hopefully’
_____	‘next time’
_____	‘very, really’
_____	‘for no reason, for free’
_____	‘tobacco’
_____	‘loon’
_____	‘I walked out, away’
_____	‘tonight’
_____ or _____	‘once, one way’
_____	‘one place’
_____ or _____	‘one person’
_____ or _____	‘in one day’
_____	‘respect’
_____	‘maggot’
_____	‘it’s foggy’
_____	‘(for the) last time’
_____	‘hardly’
_____	‘I forgot it’
_____	‘her collarbone is broken’
_____	‘a pillow is there’
_____	‘it’s on the pillow’

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Answers to writing practice 7

c'it'o	'a nest (of something)'
ditsis	'whip'
kwinegh	'by the fire'
lhilco	'half, in the middle'
cindu	'pine tree'
wilih	'maybe'
windu	'hopefully'
willhnet	'next time'
tabi	'very, really'
ts'enek	'for no reason, for free'
dek'a	'tobacco'
dedzi	'loon'
hosye	'I walked out, away'
'ëntl'an	'tonight'
'elh or 'elhikh	'once, one way'
'elhikhin	'one place'
'elhghin or 'elhhighin	'one person'
'elh dzin or 'elhidzin	'in one day'
wiggus	'respect'
c'ene'	'maggot'
ne'antsit	'it's foggy'
ts'iyenin	'(for the) last time'
'inüt'iyh	'hardly'
binewdizigilnikh	'I forgot it'
bit'ik k'intic	'her collarbone is broken'
tse'alh ggit si'ay	'a pillow is there'
tse'alh bik'it si'ay	'it's on the pillow'